

5. The memo reminds nursing staff to avoid
- (A) x-raying a patient unless pH readings exceed 5.5.
 - (B) the use of a particular method of testing pH levels.
 - (C) reliance on pH testing in patients taking acid-inhibiting medication.

Checking the position of a nasogastric tube

It is essential to confirm the position of the tube in the stomach by one of the following:

- Testing pH of aspirate: gastric placement is indicated by a pH of less than 4, but may increase to between pH 4-6 if the patient is receiving acid-inhibiting drugs. Blue litmus paper is insufficiently sensitive to adequately distinguish between levels of acidity of aspirate.
- X-rays: will only confirm position at the time the X-ray is carried out. The tube may have moved by the time the patient has returned to the ward. In the absence of a positive aspirate test, where pH readings are more than 5.5, or in a patient who is unconscious or on a ventilator, an X-ray must be obtained to confirm the initial position of the nasogastric tube.